



TORONTO YACHT CLUB

# The Boat Owner's Annual Maintenance Calendar

A month-by-month guide to keeping your boat in top condition through the Ontario season

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This calendar is built for boat owners on Lake Simcoe, Georgian Bay, and the Toronto area: slip-stored boats with a season that runs roughly from the May long weekend through late October. Adjust dates a week or two either way depending on your marina, your boat, and how the spring is shaping up. The goal: simple monthly checkpoints so nothing important sneaks up on you. Print it, save it, share it.

Toronto Yacht Club has been serving boat owners since 2017 across Keswick, Port Severn, Brechin, and the Toronto area



## In-Season Maintenance

May through October. The boat is in the water and getting used. These checkpoints catch problems early, before they become repair bills.

### May

*Splash, shake-down, set the season up right*

- Remove shrink wrap if not already off. Inspect the wrap for tears or trapped moisture before disposal.
- Wash the hull and topsides. Salt, road grime, and storage dust come off easier before they bake on in summer sun.
- Check all through-hull fittings and seacocks. Open and close each one. Stiff or seized seacocks are a haul-out emergency waiting to happen.
- Inspect bilge pumps. Pour water into the bilge to confirm the pump kicks on and cycles off cleanly.
- Test all navigation lights, horn, VHF radio. Replace any burnt bulbs now while you can still see what you're doing in daylight.
- Check safety gear: PFDs in good condition, flares not expired, fire extinguisher charged, throw cushion accessible.
- Top off fluids: engine oil, coolant, power steering, hydraulic fluid for outdrives.
- Run the engine at the dock. Listen for anything new. Watch the tell-tale stream and check exhaust water flow.
- Inspect canvas and isinglass. Clean with mild soap, treat any small tears before they grow.

*If your boat sat through a hard winter, the first hour of running is when problems show up. Don't head out for a long run on launch day.*

### June

*Get into the rhythm*

- First detail of the season. A wash, polish, and wax now protects the gel coat through the hottest months.
- Check trim tabs for proper operation and any hydraulic leaks.
- Inspect docking lines and fenders. Replace anything chafed or sun-damaged.
- Clean and treat vinyl seating. UV is brutal on marine vinyl. A good vinyl protectant every 4-6 weeks doubles its life.
- Wipe down isinglass with a dedicated isinglass cleaner, never glass cleaner with ammonia.
- Check anchor and rode. Confirm the bitter end is actually attached to the boat. (You'd be surprised.)
- Run the boat at cruising speed for a real shake-down. Note any vibration, overheating, or steering play.

## July

### *Mid-season vigilance*

- Inspect the hull below the waterline if you can. Growth on the bottom kills fuel economy and top speed.
- Watch fuel and water filters. Mid-season is when contamination from spring-launch debris tends to show up.
- Check zincs (sacrificial anodes). If more than half the zinc is gone, replace before the next outing.
- Inspect canvas snaps and zippers. A failing snap on a bimini in July is a \$20 fix; a torn canvas in August is a \$400 problem.
- Top off engine oil between full changes if your usage is heavy.
- Clean the prop. A nicked or fouled prop costs you fuel economy you can feel.

## August

### *Heavy-use month, watch for fatigue*

- Mid-season detail. Wash, light polish, and re-wax. The August sun is the hardest on gel coat all year.
- Inspect upholstery and canvas for sun fade or seam stress. Catching a failing seam now is a repair; catching it in October is a winter project.
- Check engine belts for cracking or glazing.
- Inspect outdrive bellows if applicable. Cracked bellows let water into places it should not be.
- Confirm all safety gear is still where it should be and still in working condition.
- Start thinking about winterization booking. Marinas and service shops fill up fast in late September and October. Booking now means you get the date you want.

*If you're going to need new canvas, upholstery, or a major repair before next season, August is the month to start the conversation. Lead times stretch from August through October.*

## September

### *Last full month of season, plan ahead*

- Book your winterization and haul-out date. Confirm the date in writing.
- Book any off-season work: canvas replacement, upholstery, fiberglass repair, ceramic coating. Off-season is when shops have time and best pricing.
- Inspect the bottom paint. Note where it's worn thin, plan for repaint or touch-up at haul-out.
- Check that all paperwork is current: registration, insurance, marina contract for next year if early-bird pricing applies.
- Last detail of the season if you want the boat to go into storage looking sharp. A clean boat stores better and launches better.

## October

### *Wrap-up and haul-out*

- Winterize the engine: stabilizer in fuel, fog the cylinders if applicable, drain and flush the cooling system, change the engine oil and filter.
- Drain water systems: fresh water tank, water heater, head, A/C if equipped. Add non-toxic antifreeze where needed.
- Remove all electronics that can be removed: GPS, fishfinder, VHF handhelds. Store somewhere temperature-stable.
- Strip the boat: cushions out, canvas off (or properly stored), fenders and lines coiled, anything that holds moisture indoors.
- Confirm shrink wrap or canvas cover is on tight, with proper ventilation. Trapped moisture causes more winter damage than cold ever does.
- Take photos before storage. Useful for insurance and for spotting changes when you uncover in spring.
- Pay deposits on any off-season work you've booked.

*Haul-out windows on Lake Simcoe and Georgian Bay typically run from early to late October. Book early. Last-minute haul-outs are how boats end up still in the water during the first hard freeze.*

## Off-Season Maintenance

November through April. The boat is on the hard or under wrap. Most of this work is planning, paperwork, and project work. The off-season is when the smart owners get ahead.

### November

#### *Settle in and inspect*

- Visit the boat once it's been wrapped. Confirm the wrap is still tight and ventilation is open.
- If you noticed anything during the season (a stress crack, a soft spot, a worn cushion), document it now while it's fresh.
- Review the season: how much fuel, how many hours, what broke, what surprised you. A short note now saves time at haul-out next year.
- Renew or update insurance for the off-season storage period.

### December

#### *Quiet month*

- Confirm storage premises are secure: locks intact, snow load not collapsing the wrap.
- Start the off-season project list: what do you actually want fixed, replaced, or upgraded before May?
- Begin parts research for any DIY projects. Marine parts have long lead times in winter.

### January

#### *Plan and book*

- Book your spring detail or commissioning. Slots fill fast for the May launch window.
- Confirm any off-season work that's in progress: canvas, upholstery, fiberglass, repower. Get a status update.
- Renew boat registration if it expires this year (Ontario boat registration runs in 10-year cycles for pleasure craft).
- Order any parts you'll want for spring projects.

### February

#### *Boat show season*

- Toronto International Boat Show is mid-January to early February. Worth a visit even if you're not buying: deals on accessories, new product previews, and useful conversations with manufacturers.
- Mid-winter wrap inspection. After heavy snow loads, check that nothing has shifted.
- Review last year's fuel, maintenance, and storage costs. Useful baseline for budgeting next season.

## March

### *Spring is coming*

- Confirm spring launch date with marina.
- Confirm spring detail or commissioning appointment.
- Start the de-winterization checklist: what fluids need topping, what filters need replacing, what got removed in October that needs to go back on.
- Order any consumables: oil, filters, fuel stabilizer remover (or plan for fresh fuel), zincs, polish, wax.
- Inspect trailer (if applicable): tires, bearings, lights, brakes. Trailer problems cause more season-opening delays than engine problems.

## April

### *Pre-launch*

- Remove shrink wrap on a dry day. Inspect everything that was hidden under it.
- Pre-launch wash, polish, and wax if you didn't get a spring detail booked.
- Replace zincs.
- Check battery: charge level, terminals, hold-down. Replace if 4+ years old.
- Reinstall electronics, cushions, canvas (or schedule the canvas install for after launch).
- Inspect through-hulls, seacocks, hoses. Anything that's going to leak will leak first when the boat goes in the water.
- Confirm insurance is active for the in-season period.
- Pay any outstanding marina, club, or service balances.

*Some people splash the last weekend of April. Most wait until early May. Check water temperature; if it's still in the single digits, there's no rush.*

## A Few Honest Notes

**This calendar is a starting point, not a rulebook.** Your boat, your marina, and your habits will shape the specifics. A trailered fishing boat has a different rhythm than a 35-foot cruiser slipped at Krates. Use the months as anchors and adjust to your situation.

**The biggest costs in boat ownership come from things deferred.** A small canvas tear becomes a torn enclosure. A worn zinc becomes a corroded outdrive. A skipped winterization becomes a cracked block. The work that prevents those is rarely glamorous, and it's almost always cheaper than the repair.

**You don't have to do all of this yourself.** Most boat owners do the things they enjoy and hire out the things they don't. There's no virtue in a DIY winterization that ends up costing more than a professional one. The smart move is knowing what needs doing, when, and deciding which jobs are yours and which are someone else's.

That's what this calendar is for.

### When you'd rather hand it off

Toronto Yacht Club has been serving boat owners since 2017 with detailing, canvas and upholstery, fiberglass and gel coat repair, vinyl wrap, winterization, and spring launch services. We work out of three shops on Lake Simcoe and Georgian Bay, plus mobile service in the Toronto area.

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**Locations:** Krates Marina (Keswick), Driftwood Cove (Port Severn),  
Grand Harbour (Breachin), Toronto mobile service

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